Movecia



UNFOLD · MONTH 1 · WEEKS 1-4

Roots

Arrive & make space

for .....

A LETTER FOR YOU

Hi lovely

I'm so glad you're here. If you're holding this workbook in your hands or opening it on your tablet, you've already done something big: you've given yourself a place in your own calendar. For so many of us, that's the hardest step of all, because we're so practised at thinking of everyone else first and writing ourselves somewhere at the very bottom of the list, usually just below the laundry basket.

The first month of Unfold is called Roots, and there's a good reason for that. Before anything new can grow, it needs ground to stand on. So before we talk about your ideas, your self-worth and your brave steps, we'll take an honest look together: where are you right now, what are you carrying around with you, why might you be feeling so tired, and what might your everyday life look like if it held you up instead of draining you?

I know from my own life with family, children, animals, studio and teaching how quickly you slip into simply functioning. You get things done, you organise, you keep track of everything and think ahead, and at some point you notice that you've lost sight of yourself a little along the way. That's why one thing matters so much to me: this workbook isn't another project you have to complete perfectly. It's an invitation to slow down and come back home to yourself.

For every week you'll find an in-depth reading with insights that help you understand yourself better, along with exercises, reflection questions, tables to fill in and little tips that I pass on to you just as I would share them with a good friend over a cup of tea. Some things will speak to you straight away, others perhaps only in a few weeks. Both are completely fine.

Please be kind to yourself when a week gets turbulent and you only manage half of it. Gaps are part of life, especially a life with many people who need you. You can always pick things up again from wherever you are. Nobody is handing out marks here, least of all me.

I'm so looking forward to these three months with you and the other women in our small circle. Let's put down roots together, so that you can blossom fully as yourself in spring. Remember: movement begins with you. With love, Vivien

♡ Vivien

WHAT'S INSIDE

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Your month in review

What has grown this month and what you can look forward to in Month 2.

BEFORE WE BEGIN

How to use this workbook

A few thoughts on how to weave Unfold into your everyday life without it becoming yet another obligation on your long list.

Unfold is designed to adapt to your life, so you never have to squeeze yourself into a rigid programme. Every week has its own topic, and all the pieces fit together: the movement videos bring you back into your body, the live call brings you a short talk and the chance to connect with the other women, and the workbook is the place where you go deeper, at your own pace, into whatever is on your mind right now.

Many women tell me that they start a programme full of energy and then feel bad after two weeks because they haven't managed everything. That's exactly what I want to spare you here. Think of each week as a beautifully laid buffet: you take what nourishes you and what you have room for right now. If in one week you only manage the short Thursday video and answer a single journal question, that's a real contribution to your wellbeing.

Your rhythm in an Unfold week

1. Monday: your Full Day video is released. It lasts about 30 minutes and is meant for days when you have a little energy to spare. You can do it any time during the week; Monday is simply the day it unlocks.
2. Live call: once a week we meet in our small circle. I give a short talk on the week's topic, then we work on it together and share our experiences. If you can't join, you'll find the recording in your members' area.
3. Workbook: ideally, read the week's insight before or after the call. You can spread the exercises and questions across the whole week, for example ten minutes every evening.
4. Thursday: your Tired Day video is released. It lasts about 15 minutes and is meant for days when you're tired but would still like to do something for yourself. Many of these flows happen almost entirely lying down.
5. Journaling: take a few minutes on one evening at the weekend to look back on your week. The journal questions at the end of each chapter will help you.

GOOD TO KNOW

Why movement and reflection belong together

Our body and our mind aren't separate systems. When we're stressed, our muscles tighten, our breathing becomes shallower and our thinking narrows. Gentle, mindful movement can help the body find its way back into a calmer state, and from that calmer state it's often easier to look honestly at things and make good decisions. That's why so much in Unfold begins in the body before we put it into words in the workbook.

What you need

- A mat, a blanket and a cushion for the movement videos, and for some flows also a yoga block, a wall or a chair.
- This workbook, printed out or as a PDF on your tablet, and a pen that feels good in your hand.
- A place where you can be undisturbed for a few minutes. That could just as well be the car outside the nursery or the bathtub.
- A cup of tea or coffee and your own permission to truly use this time for yourself.

My tip for you

Put the workbook somewhere you'll see it, for example next to your coffee machine or on your bedside table. We're far more likely to pick up what we can see. And if you don't feel like filling in a page, simply turn to the next one. You're also allowed to doodle, cross things out and write in the margins whatever is going through your mind.

Gaps are allowed

There will be weeks when a child gets ill, your job takes everything you have or you simply have no strength left. In weeks like these, even the smallest thing you do for yourself is still valuable: a few conscious breaths before falling asleep, five minutes lying down with your hands on your heart and belly, a single sentence in your journal. When you come back afterwards, you're not starting from scratch. You simply carry on, and everything you've worked on so far is still there.

I'm allowed to grow at my own pace. Every small step counts.

Your weekly tracker (template to copy or fill in)

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Full Day video	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Tired Day video	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Live call or recording	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Workbook time	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Five minutes of conscious breathing	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Time outside in the fresh air	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
One sentence in my journal	○	○	○	○	○	○	○



Before we begin

What made me decide to sign up for Unfold?

When in my week could my Unfold time realistically fit in?

What or who could help me keep going?



WEEK 1

Where are you right now?

In this first week, you arrive. We take a loving and honest look at your life just as it is right now, and we gather your wishes for the next three months.

This week's insight

Imagine you want to go on a hike and you open a map. Before you can even think about which path to take, you need a little dot that says: you are here. Without that dot, even the most beautiful map is useless. Our lives work in a very similar way. We often have a sense of where we want to go, or at least an inkling that something ought to change, but we rarely take the time to work out, quite honestly, where we actually stand right now.

There are good reasons for that. The everyday life of a woman with family, job, household and all the big and small commitments usually runs at full speed. We react to whatever comes next: the child who needs picking up, the email still waiting for a reply, the fridge that's empty. There's hardly any room to pause, and sometimes we also avoid it a little, because we sense that a closer look might reveal things that hurt or that we would then have to deal with.

I would like to give you something for this week that has helped me a great deal: taking stock of where you are isn't a school report. You're not looking at your life to judge it or to reproach yourself for everything that doesn't fit. You're looking so that you can get to know yourself better, just as you would listen to a friend telling you about her life. With a friend, you wouldn't judge straight away either. You would ask questions, want to understand, and perhaps say: no wonder you're tired, with everything you're carrying at the moment.

This week, you're invited to offer yourself exactly that kind of friendly curiosity. Perhaps you'll discover that some areas of your life are going really well and that you've never truly appreciated them. Perhaps you'll notice that one area has been neglected for a very long time, such as your friendships, your creativity or your sleep. Both are valuable pieces of information. They show you where you have strength to build on and where you would like to give yourself more attention over the coming months.

One tool I love for taking stock is the wheel of life. You look at different areas of your life and give each one a number between 1 and 10, depending on how satisfied you feel with it at the moment. This is about your own feeling and not about any objective standard. A woman who exercises five times a week can still give movement a 4 because it makes her feel stressed, and a woman who takes the dog for a short walk every evening can give it an 8 because that's exactly what she needs. Your numbers belong to you alone.

When you see the numbers in front of you, you'll probably notice a pattern. The areas are often connected: when sleep is poor, patience with the family drops too, and when there's no time for friends, your own mood feels heavier as well. You don't have to change everything at once. Quite the opposite: it's often enough to lift a single area a little, and the others will often rise a little along with it, all on their own.

The second part of this week is all about your wishes. I'm choosing the word wish very deliberately and avoiding the word resolution. Resolutions often have something strict about them; they sound like discipline and like a guilty conscience when things don't work out. A wish, on the other hand, comes from the heart. It describes how you would like to feel and what truly matters to you. A wish such as “I would like to feel calmer in the evenings again” can later turn into very concrete small steps, but at the beginning there's the feeling you're longing for.

Perhaps you find it hard to put any wish for yourself into words at all. Many women feel the same, especially when for years they've mostly focused on everyone else's wishes. Then it's perfectly fine to start small. What would you wish for on a perfectly ordinary Tuesday? Half an hour in which nobody wants anything from you? A warm lunch that you eat sitting down? A conversation in which you're not only the one listening? Small wishes like these are often the key to the big ones.

And then there's your body. In this first week, the two movement videos invite you to arrive fully in yourself. Movement begins with you, and I mean that literally: with your feet, which carry you every single day, with your breath, which accompanies you without you having to think about it, and with the strength of your legs, which often achieve far more than we give them credit for. When you feel a little safer and more grounded in your body again, taking stock becomes easier too.



GOOD TO KNOW

Your videos this week

Monday: “Putting down roots” (about 30 min.). The opening flow: you feel your feet, your breath and the strength of your legs, calm, clear and unhurried. Thursday: “Arriving softly” (about 15 min.). For days when everything is too much, mostly lying down and with lots of space to notice how you feel.



GOOD TO KNOW

Why writing things down helps

Psychologists have been studying for decades how writing regularly about our thoughts and feelings affects our wellbeing. Many studies on expressive writing suggest that it can help us order our thoughts, process difficult experiences better and gain a clearer picture of our own situation. What matters is less the beauty of the sentences than their honesty. You're writing for yourself, and nobody else needs to read it.



GOOD TO KNOW

The wheel of life

The wheel of life is a well-known coaching tool. It shows at a glance how balanced different areas of life feel right now. When you mark the numbers on a circle and join them up, you get a shape that's rarely perfectly round. That's normal and completely fine. The wheel is meant to show you a direction, not to set an ideal you have to reach.

Taking stock

Give yourself about ten minutes for the following scale. Read each area, close your eyes for a moment and notice which number feels right straight away. The first number that comes to mind is often the most honest one. At the end of this month you'll fill in the same scale again and can compare.

How satisfied am I right now with ...

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
my body and my movement										
my sleep and my rest										
my energy in everyday life										
my relationship										
my family and my home										
my friendships										
my work or my career										
my finances										
my creativity and my ideas										
time just for me										
my inner calm										
my self-worth										
	not at all									very

Reading your wheel of life

15 minutes

Once you've filled in the scale, take a calm look at it. These questions will help you get more out of your numbers.

1. Mark the two areas with the highest numbers. Think about what exactly is going well there at the moment and what you contribute to it.
2. Mark the two areas with the lowest numbers. Ask yourself how long it has felt this way and what changed back then.
3. Consider which areas are connected. If one of them improved, which would automatically follow?
4. Choose one area you would like to give special attention to over the next three months, and write it in large letters on the lines below.
5. Note which number would feel good for this area in three months' time. Even one or two points higher is a noticeable change.

My focus area for Unfold

Arriving in your body

5 minutes

You'll recognise this little practice from this week's videos. You can do it every day, even in bed or on the sofa, before you start working with the workbook.

1. Lie on your back or sit comfortably. Place one hand on your breastbone and the other below your belly button.
2. Breathe normally, without trying to change anything, and notice which hand rises first.
3. Feel the warmth of your hands and how it slowly spreads through your body.
4. Then breathe in through your nose for a count of 4 a few times and out through slightly parted lips for a count of 6, as if you were gently blowing through a straw.
5. Afterwards, stay lying down for a moment and ask yourself: how am I really feeling right now?

My tip for you

If you notice that a low number makes you sad, place your hand on your heart and say to yourself: I'm glad I can see this now. It may sound simple, but it makes a huge difference whether you meet yourself with strictness or with warmth. You've set out on this path, and that's exactly what Unfold is here for.

Your wishes for the three months

Now it's time to dream. Imagine it's early April, your three months of Unfold are behind you, and you're sitting with a cup of tea in the first spring sunshine. How do you feel? What's different from today? What have you discovered for yourself? Write your answers as if everything has already happened. This helps your mind truly picture the change.

A letter from spring

20 minutes

This exercise is one of my favourites. You write a short letter from your future self to the self you are today.

1. Find a quiet moment and read the question once more: how does my life feel in early April?
2. Begin your letter with “Dear …” and your name. Write in the present tense, as if it were already true.
3. Describe a perfectly ordinary day: how you wake up, how you move, how you speak to yourself, what you've handed over and what you treat yourself to.
4. Tell your present self what helped along the way and what she can trust in.
5. Sign the letter, fold it and tuck it into this workbook. At the end of Unfold you'll read it again.

My wishes for Unfold

Wish	How would I like to feel?	A first small step

What I would like to allow myself in these three months

- [ ] To be slower than I'm used to
- [ ] To ask for help without justifying myself
- [ ] To begin imperfectly
- [ ] To regularly take time just for myself
- [ ] To be tired and still feel valuable
- [ ] To take my own wishes seriously
- [ ] To skip a week and then simply carry on

I'm standing exactly where my path begins. From here, I'm allowed to grow.

Journal questions for week 1

If my life right now were a kind of weather, what would it be and why?

What have I been carrying around for a long time that I would finally like to look at?

What am I proud of in my life as it is now, even if I rarely say it out loud?

How did I feel after this week's movement videos?

Which wish for the three months matters most to me, and why this one in particular?

My tracker for week 1

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Video “Putting down roots”	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Video “Arriving softly”	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Live call or recording	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Taking stock completed	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Arriving in your body (5 min.)	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
One sentence in my journal	○	○	○	○	○	○	○



WEEK 2

Making your mental load visible

This week we get everything you carry around in your head down on paper. Only once the invisible work becomes visible can you decide what you would like to keep and what you would like to hand over.

This week's insight

Do you know that feeling of sitting exhausted on the sofa in the evening and wondering why on earth you're so tired, when you haven't really done anything big? If you then try to list everything you got done that day, perhaps only a handful of things come to mind. And yet your head feels like a browser with thirty tabs open. That very feeling has a name: mental load.

Mental load means the invisible mental work needed to keep a household, a family and a shared life running. Above all, it covers everything that happens before and after the actual doing, in other words before and after the shopping, the cooking or the laundry. Someone has to remember that the trainers are getting too small, that a vaccination is due at the paediatrician's, that Grandma has a birthday next week and that a packed lunch is needed for the school hike. Someone has to consider the options, make a decision and keep an eye on whether everything worked out.

This kind of work has three qualities that make it so exhausting. First, it's invisible: nobody sees that you're already going through tomorrow's meal plan while brushing your teeth. Second, it never stops, because there's no clocking off from thinking ahead; it keeps running in the background, as you fall asleep, on holiday and sometimes even at three in the morning. And third, it's rarely recognised, precisely because it's not perceived as work, not even by ourselves.

Studies from various countries show that in many families the work of thinking ahead and planning is still done mainly by women, even when both partners work and the visible tasks already seem to be shared fairly. Usually this isn't down to ill will. Often it has simply settled into place, for example during the years when the children were small and one person was at home more. What frequently remains from that time is a role that was never renegotiated: the role of the family's project manager.

Perhaps you've heard the line “You should have asked”. It's usually meant kindly, and yet it goes right to the heart of the problem. Whoever has to ask still carries the responsibility for knowing what needs doing and only delegates individual tasks. So the load in your head stays with you. Real relief only comes when someone else takes over an area completely, from remembering it to doing it and checking afterwards.

This week I would like to invite you to take an inventory. That may sound like bookkeeping, but it's one of the most liberating exercises I know. You write down everything you feel responsible for, truly everything, from the tax return to buying more toothpaste. Many women are shocked the first time by how long the list gets. At the same time, they feel enormous relief, because they finally see in black and white why they're so tired. It's not because they can't cope. They're simply carrying a great deal.

In the second step you look at your list and ask yourself, for each task, who remembers it, who does it and whether someone else could take it over. Feel free to think generously here. Perhaps your partner could

take on a whole area, such as the children's doctor's appointments or the weekly shop. Perhaps the children could take on more responsibility in a way that suits their age, for example for their own sports bag or for feeding the pets. Perhaps there are things you can outsource, such as a drinks delivery service or a cleaner every other week. And some things may simply be dropped altogether.

I want to be honest with you: handing things over isn't always easy. Sometimes it's more convenient to do things yourself, because it's quicker and because we know how we want them done. When you hand over an area, at first it will probably be done differently from how you would do it. The lunchbox might be packed differently, the shopping might include a different brand of yoghurt, and the birthday present might not be the one you would have chosen. This is where it pays to take a deep breath and ask yourself: does it really matter, or is it just different?

To round off the week, you'll find a conversation guide for your family. A conversation about how tasks are shared works best in a calm moment, not in the middle of an argument about the dishwasher nobody emptied. You can speak from your own experience and describe how you're feeling without accusing anyone. Most partners, and many children too, respond with more understanding than we expect once they see the list with their own eyes.

Your body gets fitting support this week as well. In the Full Day video you wake up your deep core, the centre that keeps you stable, and you do it without holding your breath. I find this image very fitting: a strong centre doesn't mean carrying everything alone; it means standing tall and distributing the weight wisely. And the Tired Day video gives your back, which carries so much, a calm quarter of an hour.



GOOD TO KNOW

Your videos this week

Monday: “Strong centre, calm breath” (about 30 min.). You wake up your deep core without holding your breath. Thursday: “Let your back breathe” (about 15 min.). A gentle practice for a tired, tense back.



GOOD TO KNOW

The four steps of invisible mental work

The sociologist Allison Daminger studied the cognitive work in families more closely and described four steps: anticipating that something needs doing, researching the options, making a decision and then monitoring whether everything is going well. Her research showed that the anticipating and the monitoring in particular often fell to women, while decisions were more often made together. So when you look at your tasks, pay special attention to these two invisible ends.

GOOD TO KNOW

Why open tasks cost so much energy

Our brain tends to remember unfinished tasks especially well and keeps bringing them back into our awareness. In psychology this is often linked to what's known as the Zeigarnik effect. Research also suggests that writing down open tasks and making a concrete plan for them can noticeably ease the mind, because the brain can then trust that nothing will get lost.

Your mental load inventory

Fill in the table at your leisure, ideally spread over several days, because new things will keep occurring to you once you've started. I've already entered a few typical tasks to help you get going. Cross out whatever doesn't apply to you and add whatever is missing. Simply put a cross in the columns or write in a name.

Inventory part 1 · Family and household

Task	I remember it	I do it	Someone else could take it over
Planning the weekly shop and writing the shopping list			
Meal plan and packed lunches for the week			
Children's doctor and dentist appointments			
Keeping track of the children's clothes and shoes			
Birthdays, presents and invitations			
School and nursery letters, parents' evenings			
Lifts to hobbies and friends' houses			
Washing, hanging up and putting away laundry			
Household supplies such as detergent and toilet paper			
Feeding the pets, vet visits, buying more food			
Planning holidays and childcare			
Keeping in touch with grandparents and relatives			

Inventory part 2 · Organisation, finances and everything else

Task	I remember it	I do it	Someone else could take it over
Bills, insurance, contracts			
Car, servicing, changing tyres			
Repairs around the house and tradespeople's appointments			
Planning holidays and weekend trips			
Keeping the family calendar up to date			
My own doctor's appointments and check-ups			



Looking at your list



20 minutes

Once your tables are filled in, take a short break, drink a glass of water and then look at them with fresh eyes.

1. Count how many tasks you've put a cross next to in the column “I remember it”. Write the number in large figures in the margin.
2. Using one colour, mark all the tasks that bring you joy or that matter so much to you that you're happy to keep them.
3. Using a second colour, mark all the tasks that weigh on you most or that you've disliked doing for a long time.
4. From the second colour, choose two or three tasks that you would like to hand over completely in the coming weeks, from remembering them to doing them.
5. For each of these tasks, consider who could take it over and what this person needs to know to do it well.

My tip for you

When you hand over an area, hand it over completely, even if it's hard. That means you no longer ask, remind or check. At first something might be forgotten, and the other person usually learns from that faster than from any reminder of yours. I know how tempting it will be to step in, but this calm is a real gift to yourself.

Handing over, but how?

There are different ways to let go of tasks. Not every task has to go to your partner. Some suit older children beautifully, some you can outsource, and some you can simply cross off because they're done more out of habit than out of real necessity. This checklist will help you find the right way for each task that weighs on you.

Handing-over checklist

- [ ] I've chosen two or three tasks that I would like to hand over completely.
- [ ] I've checked whether one of these tasks can be dropped altogether.
- [ ] I've considered which tasks the children can take on in a way that suits their age.
- [ ] I've considered whether something can be outsourced, for example through delivery services, lift shares or help in the house.
- [ ] For each task, I've written down what the person taking it over needs to know.
- [ ] I've found a calm moment for a family conversation.
- [ ] I've resolved not to check up on tasks I've handed over.
- [ ] I've thought about what I would like to do with the time and calm I gain.

GOOD TO KNOW

What children can take on at which age

Children can often do more than we think, and responsibility in family life strengthens their self-confidence. Nursery-age children can, for example, tidy away their shoes, help set the table or sort socks. Primary school children can pack their own school bag, feed the pets or empty the dishwasher. Older children and teenagers can enter their own appointments in the family calendar, cook simple meals, do their own laundry and take over one fixed area of the household completely. How much is possible naturally depends on each child.

A conversation guide for your family

A good conversation about mental load needs a little preparation. Choose a time when you're both rested and not under time pressure, for example at the weekend after breakfast or on an evening when the children are already asleep. Bring your inventory list with you, because it makes visible what's otherwise hard to explain.

1. Begin with yourself and your feelings, for example: “Over the last few weeks I've noticed how exhausted I am, and I would love to talk with you about how we share the planning in our family.”
2. Show your list and briefly explain what mental load means: the work of remembering, planning and following up that comes on top of actually doing things.
3. Ask the other person to describe their own view. Perhaps your partner carries things you weren't even aware of. Listen without answering straight away.

4. Decide together which areas someone else will take over completely. Talk about everything each area involves, so it's clear that the thinking ahead is handed over too.
5. Agree on how you'll share information, for example through a shared family calendar or a shopping list on your phones.
6. Set a date in three to four weeks to talk briefly about how it's going and what you would like to adjust.
7. Thank the other person for the conversation and say what you valued about it.



My notes for the conversation



The evening brain dump



5 minutes

You can do this little exercise every evening from now on, so that the open tabs in your head don't come to bed with you.

1. Put a piece of paper or a notebook next to your bed.
2. Write down everything that's still going through your head, without sorting or judging it.
3. Mark no more than three things that really matter tomorrow.
4. Put the paper aside and tell yourself: it's written down, I can let go now.
5. To finish, breathe in deeply three times and breathe out slowly.

I don't have to keep everything in my head. I'm allowed to share, hand over and lighten my load.



Journal questions for week 2

Which task on my list surprised me the most?

What thoughts or feelings come up when I think about handing something over?

Where do I feel that things only go right if I do them myself? Where does that feeling come from?

How did the conversation with my family go, or what's still holding me back from having it?

What would I do with one free hour a week that nobody is allowed to take from me?

My tracker for week 2

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Video “Strong centre, calm breath”	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Video “Let your back breathe”	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Live call or recording	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Inventory added to	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Evening brain dump	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Handed over one task	○	○	○	○	○	○	○

WEEK 3

Understanding exhaustion

This week you get to know your nervous system better. When you understand why you're so tired, you can refuel in a more targeted way and treat yourself more lovingly.

This week's insight

Exhaustion is one of the topics I talk about most often with women. Many describe a tiredness that doesn't go away even after a weekend off, a feeling of being constantly wired and at the same time having no strength left. Some feel a little ashamed of it, because they think others seem to manage just fine. This week I would like to show you that your exhaustion makes sense and that your body is trying to tell you something important.

To understand this, it's worth taking a short detour into our nervous system. A large part of it works entirely automatically, without us having to think about it consciously. This part, known as the autonomic nervous system, controls, for example, our heartbeat, our breathing, our digestion and our body temperature. It has two main players, which you can imagine as two pedals in a car: an accelerator and a brake.

The accelerator is the sympathetic nervous system. It becomes active when we're challenged or perceive danger. Then the heart beats faster, breathing becomes shallower and quicker, the muscles tense, and the body releases stress hormones such as adrenaline and cortisol. This is a wonderful ability that helps us react quickly in difficult situations, for example when a child runs into the road or we're giving an important presentation. So the sympathetic nervous system is our friend, as long as it only takes the wheel for a while.

The brake is the parasympathetic nervous system. It makes sure we can rest, digest, regenerate and sleep well. When it's active, the heartbeat calms, the breath becomes deeper and slower, and the body has the chance to replenish its reserves. An important part of this system is the vagus nerve, a long nerve that runs from the brainstem down into the abdomen and connects many organs. A calm, lengthened exhale is one of the simplest ways to gently support this brake.

In a healthy rhythm, accelerator and brake take turns throughout the day. We make an effort, then we recover, then we make an effort again. The problem in our modern everyday life is that many of us hardly ever take our foot off the accelerator. The demands never let up, the phone pings constantly, and even during breaks we're already thinking about what comes next. So the body stays in a kind of permanent alarm, even when, objectively speaking, we're sitting on the sofa.

This is where an image comes in that I find very helpful: the window of tolerance. The psychiatrist Daniel Siegel coined this term. It describes a zone in which we can cope well with the demands of life. Inside this window we feel alert and at the same time calm enough to think clearly, feel and respond to others. When stress becomes too great, we slip out of the window, either upwards into hyperarousal with irritability, restlessness and racing thoughts, or downwards into hypoarousal with exhaustion, emptiness and the sense of no longer feeling anything.

Many exhausted women swing back and forth between these two states. During the day they run at full speed, and in the evening they sink into a leaden tiredness in which all they can do is scroll through their phone. Neither of these is a weakness of character. They're the responses of a nervous system that has had to carry too much for too long. The good news is that the window of tolerance can widen again over time when we regularly give the body moments of safety and rest.

A second image I would like to give you is the stress bucket. Imagine you carry a bucket inside you into which water flows every day: the sleepless night, the argument with your teenager, the deadline pressure at work, the worry about your parents, the noise, the hormones and also the many small things that are barely worth mentioning on their own. Every bucket has a certain size, and when it's full, a single drop is enough to make it overflow. Then we suddenly react to something small like spilt milk with tears or anger and are surprised at ourselves.

The crucial thing about this image is that every bucket also has a tap. Water can drain out through it, through everything that truly restores us: movement, sleep, time in nature, an honest conversation with a friend, laughing, crying, creative work or simply a few calm breaths. When we regularly let a little water out, there's room for the unavoidable strains of life. That's why small daily moments of rest are often more effective than one big holiday a year.

So this week you'll take a close look: what fills your bucket, and what empties it again? Which people, activities and habits drain your energy, and which give it to you? Sometimes the answers are surprising. Perhaps you'll notice that scrolling in the evening doesn't actually relax you, even though it feels as if it does, and that ten minutes of mucking out the stable, gardening or a walk at dusk bring you far more calm.

This week's movement videos support you in exactly that. In the Full Day video you build strength in your legs and glutes, a strength that gives you stability in everyday life and gives many women the feeling of standing firmly on both feet again. In the Tired Day video you get to shake, sway and set down whatever the day has loaded onto you. Shaking out in particular is a wonderfully simple way to release built-up tension from the body.

GOOD TO KNOW

Your videos this week

Monday: “Legs that carry you” (about 30 min.). Strength in your legs and glutes that gives you stability in everyday life. Thursday: “Letting go of heaviness” (about 16 min.). Shake, sway, release: let go of everything the day has piled onto you. To finish, you lie with your legs up the wall.

GOOD TO KNOW

Accelerator and brake at a glance

The sympathetic nervous system prepares the body for performance: a faster heartbeat, faster breathing, tense muscles, alert senses, and digestion is turned down. The parasympathetic nervous system guides the body into rest: a calmer heartbeat, deeper breathing, relaxed muscles, digestion at work, the body regenerating. Both systems are vital. What's healthy is a flexible switch between them, depending on what the situation needs.

GOOD TO KNOW

When you should seek support

If you feel exhausted for weeks on end, sleep badly, hardly feel any joy or have the sense that everything is getting on top of you, please talk to your GP. Persistent tiredness can also have physical causes, such as iron deficiency or a thyroid disorder, which can easily be checked. And if the emotional strain doesn't ease, a psychotherapist can be a valuable companion. Seeking help is a sign of strength.

Your stress bucket

What flows into your bucket?

15 minutes

Draw a large bucket on the lines below or on a separate sheet. With this exercise you make visible what's weighing on you right now and what eases the pressure.

1. Inside the bucket, write everything that's weighing on you at the moment. That includes big things such as worries or conflicts and small things such as noise, mess or constant interruptions.
2. Draw a tap at the bottom of the bucket and write next to it everything that helps you release pressure.
3. Look at how full your bucket is right now and mark the water level with a line.
4. Consider whether there's anything you let flow into the bucket even though it's not really necessary, such as certain news, group chats or commitments.
5. Choose one tap that you would like to open a little every day this week, and write it in large letters underneath.

My stress bucket

Energy drains and energy sources

Observe yourself for a few days this week and note what drains your energy and what gives you energy. Pay attention to the small things too, because it's often the many little drains that add up over the day. I've already entered a few examples for you.

What drains my energy, what gives it to me?

Energy drain	How strong? (1–10)	Energy source	How often do I treat myself to it?
Scrolling on my phone for ages in the evening		A walk in the fresh air	
Constant interruptions while working		A conversation with a friend	
Too little sleep		Ten minutes of movement	

Your battery check: how charged is my battery right now …

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
physically										
emotionally										
mentally										
in my relationships										
in my creativity										
overall										

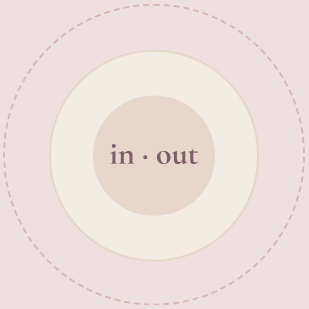
empty full

My tip for you

Feel free to do the battery check several times a week, for example in the morning over your first coffee. Over time you'll recognise your patterns: perhaps your battery is always empty after certain appointments, or it recharges remarkably well after certain activities. On low-battery days you consciously choose the Tired Day video, and that's a wise decision, not an excuse.

Breathing to find the brake

The breath is a bridge to our nervous system, because it's one of the few automatic processes we can also influence consciously. An exhale that lasts longer than the inhale is often associated with activating the parasympathetic nervous system. Many people find that after just a few rounds their shoulders drop and their mind grows quieter. This breathing practice also accompanies you in several of the movement videos.



BREATHWORK

Long exhale

4 · 6

Sit comfortably or lie on your back. Breathe in through your nose, slowly counting to 4. Breathe out through slightly parted lips, counting to 6, as softly as if you were blowing through a straw. Repeat this six to eight times. If 6 still feels too long, start with 4 in and 5 out. If it feels good, you can gradually lengthen the exhale to 8. If you feel dizzy, simply return to your natural breath.

The mini pause for any time of day

2 minutes

You can do this little sequence anywhere: in the car outside school, at your desk or in the kitchen while the pasta water comes to the boil.

1. Feel your feet on the floor and gently press your heel, the ball of your big toe and the ball of your little toe into the ground.
2. Breathe in twice in a row through your nose and then sigh out long and audibly through your mouth. Repeat this physiological sigh three times.
3. Let your gaze wander slowly around the room and let it rest on something you find pleasant, such as a ray of light, a plant or a colour.
4. Take three more rounds of breathing in for 4 and out for 6.
5. Notice whether anything has changed, and then return to your day.

Sleep, your most important source of rest

Good sleep is one of the most important ways to recharge your battery. At the same time, for many women with children, with shift work or in hormonally turbulent phases of life, it's anything but a given. You can't control everything that disturbs your sleep, but a few habits can help your body settle more easily in the evening.

- Try to go to bed and get up at roughly the same time, even at the weekend. A regular rhythm helps your internal clock.

- Get some daylight in the morning, ideally outdoors. Morning light helps your body feel sleepy in the evening.
- Put your phone aside about an hour before bed. Bright screens and stimulating content keep your nervous system awake.
- Make sure your bedroom is cool, dark and quiet.
- It's best to avoid coffee or black tea in the afternoon and evening, and go easy on alcohol at night, because it often makes sleep more restless in the second half of the night.
- Use the evening brain dump from week 2 and the long-exhale breathing practice to consciously press the brake before falling asleep.
- If you lie awake at night brooding, get up briefly, have a sip of water and write down your thoughts instead of tossing and turning in bed.

GOOD TO KNOW

Sleep and hormones

Many women notice that their sleep changes in certain phases of life, for example in the days before their period, after giving birth or in the years around the menopause. Hormonal changes can affect falling asleep and staying asleep and can lead to night sweats or waking early. If sleep problems weigh on you over a longer period, it's worth talking to your gynaecologist or GP.

My tiredness is a message. I listen to it and give myself rest.

Journal questions for week 3

How can I tell that I'm slipping out of my window of tolerance, upwards or downwards?

When in the last few weeks did I feel truly rested? What was different then?

Which energy drain in my life would be easiest to shrink?

How did my body feel after shaking out in the Thursday video?

What would I advise an exhausted friend, and can I give myself that same advice?

My tracker for week 3

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Video “Legs that carry you”	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Video “Letting go of heaviness”	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Live call or recording	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Long exhale (4 · 6)	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Phone away an hour before bed	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Daylight in the morning	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Battery check	○	○	○	○	○	○	○



WEEK 4

Organisation that lightens the load

In the last week of this month we bring everything together. You'll find simple routines, a relaxed way of planning your week and small anchors for your mornings and evenings that give your everyday life more room to breathe.

This week's insight

When we hear the word organisation, many of us think of colour-coded calendars, perfectly labelled storage jars and women on social media who get up at five in the morning and have already meditated, worked out and set their goals for the day before breakfast. Perhaps you've tried to adopt a system like that yourself and given up after a few days, feeling that you're simply not organised enough. This week I would like to introduce you to a completely different kind of organisation.

For me, good organisation has one single aim: it should lighten your load. It should clear your head, take decisions off your plate and make sure there's more room in everyday life for what matters to you. A system that stresses you even more because you can't keep it up misses that aim. That's why this week comes with one principle I would really like you to take to heart: as simple as possible, and better a small system you actually use than a big one gathering dust in a drawer.

Over the last three weeks you've already prepared a great deal. You know where you stand and what you wish for. You've made your mental load visible and perhaps already handed over some tasks. And you understand how your nervous system works and what fills your battery. All of this now flows into your organisation, because a weekly plan that truly lightens the load takes into account your energy and your rest as well as appointments and tasks.

The first building block is a short weekly planning session. Many women simply let their week come at them without planning it consciously. At first that feels flexible, but it often means we're constantly reacting instead of shaping things ourselves. Even twenty minutes on a Sunday evening or Monday morning can make a big difference. You look at the appointments for the coming week, think about what really matters and consciously plan in breaks and time for yourself. At the end of this chapter you'll find a weekly planner for exactly that.

An important part of this planning is the question of priorities. I recommend that you choose no more than three things per week that truly matter to you. These can be tasks, such as signing up for summer camp, but also things for yourself, such as doing the movement video twice or calling a friend. Once these three things are done, the week was a good one, no matter what else is still on the list. This limit may feel unfamiliar at first, but it protects you from the feeling of never being finished.

The second building block is routines. Routines are like well-trodden paths in the woods: they save energy because we don't have to work out the way every single time. Every decision we don't have to make lightens our mind. That might be a set order in the morning, a fixed shopping day, a weekly dinner plan or a particular place for keys, glasses and school bags. Little structures like these sound unspectacular, but they take a lot of the rush out of everyday life.

If you want to build new habits, a trick that's well described in behavioural research can help: link the new habit to something you already do every day anyway. The behaviour scientist BJ Fogg calls these existing habits anchors. You might decide, for example: after I pour my coffee in the morning, I breathe out slowly three times. Or: after I brush my teeth in the evening, I write one sentence in my journal. The smaller the new habit, the easier it is to anchor.

The third building block is your personal anchors for morning and evening. The morning often sets the mood we carry into the day. If it begins with reaching for the phone, with news, emails and group chats, we're stressed before we've even got out of bed. A small morning anchor, even if it's only a glass of water and three conscious breaths at the open window, gives you a moment that belongs to you alone. The evening, in turn, is the bridge to rest. An evening anchor helps your nervous system switch from the accelerator to the brake.

I would like to share one more thought that has taken a lot of pressure off me personally: good enough is often truly good enough. Not every meal has to be home-cooked and balanced, not every room has to be tidy before you're allowed to sit down, and not every invitation calls for a home-baked cake. When you consciously settle for good enough in some places, you gain strength for the things that are truly close to your heart.

And finally: plan in buffers. Everyday life with children, animals and a job is unpredictable. A child gets ill, the washing machine breaks down, an appointment runs over. If your week is planned down to the last minute, every small disruption throws you off balance. If, on the other hand, you consciously leave gaps, you can absorb surprises like these without everything collapsing at once. And if no surprise comes along, you've been given the gift of time.

The movement videos that close this month combine strength and calm in a lovely way. In the Full Day video you make your hips and pelvis mobile and strong, and it can feel lively and a little like dancing. In the Tired Day video you calm your nervous system with humming, long exhales and gentle holds. This brings us full circle to week 3, and you now have a whole collection of small tools you can weave into your everyday life at any time.

GOOD TO KNOW

Your videos this week

Monday: “Pelvis in motion” (about 30 min.). Your hips and pelvis become mobile and strong, and it can feel lively and a little like dancing. Thursday: “Calming your nervous system” (about 15 min.). Humming, long exhales and gentle holds to help your body come out of alarm mode.

GOOD TO KNOW

If-then plans

The psychologist Peter Gollwitzer researched how people can follow through on their intentions more successfully. One result of his work is if-then plans, known in research as implementation intentions. Instead of resolving to take better care of yourself, you decide exactly what you'll do in which situation: when I've put the children to bed on Thursday evening, I'll roll out my mat and start the Tired Day video. Many studies show that concrete plans like these can make following through considerably easier.

GOOD TO KNOW

Why too many decisions make us tired

Over the course of a day we make countless small decisions, from what to have for dinner to which clothes the children should wear. Many people find that by the evening they have less patience and clarity left for decisions. Fixed routines, weekly meal plans and clear responsibilities in the family can help reduce the number of these small decisions and keep your mind free for what really matters.

Your weekly planning session

Choose a fixed time for your weekly planning, for example on Sunday evening when the house grows quieter, or on Monday morning after your first coffee. Make yourself comfortable with tea, a candle or your favourite music. These twenty minutes are a gift to your future self.

Your weekly planning in seven steps

20 minutes

You can repeat these steps every week. Over time, planning becomes a little ritual that gives you calm and a clear overview.

1. Look back briefly: what went well last week, and what would you like to do differently?
2. Write down everything that's on your mind for the coming week, without sorting it.
3. Enter all fixed appointments in the planner, including those of the children and your partner where they affect you.
4. Choose no more than three priorities for this week and write them where you can see them clearly.
5. Schedule your movement videos and the live call as fixed appointments with yourself.
6. Enter at least one self-care slot that belongs to you alone, and leave a small buffer free every day.
7. Consider what you can hand over to others or consciously leave out, and agree on it with your family if necessary.



PLANNER

My weekly planner

Mon

Tue

Wed

Thu

Fri

Sat

Sun

MY TOP THREE PRIORITIES

SOMETHING JUST FOR ME

My tip for you

A shared family calendar is one of the most effective tools against mental load. Whether it's a paper calendar on the kitchen wall or a shared calendar on your phones, what matters is that each person enters their own appointments. That way you're no longer the family's walking diary, and everyone has the same overview.

Simple routines that lighten the load

The following list is a collection of small routines that make everyday life easier for many women. You don't have to adopt them all. Read through them, tick whatever appeals to you, and to begin with choose no more than two that you would like to try over the coming weeks.

Routines to try

- [ ] A fixed weekly dinner plan with recurring dishes, such as soup night, pasta night and leftovers night
- [ ] A fixed shopping day with a shared shopping list that everyone may add to
- [ ] A fixed place for keys, glasses, post and school bags right by the front door
- [ ] Laying out clothes and bags for the next day the evening before
- [ ] Five minutes of tidying up together as a whole family before dinner
- [ ] A charging station for phones outside the bedroom
- [ ] A ten-minute weekly family check-in in which everyone briefly talks through their week
- [ ] A basket for everything that still needs doing or putting away, emptied once a week
- [ ] Repeat orders for things like detergent, toilet paper or pet food

Your anchors for morning and evening

An anchor is a small, loving action that connects you with yourself. It doesn't have to take long; two to ten minutes is quite enough. What matters is that it happens regularly and is linked to something you already do every day anyway. Let the following ideas inspire you and then create your own anchors.

Ideas for your anchors

Morning anchor	Evening anchor
Drink a large glass of water before you reach for your phone	Use the evening brain dump from week 2
Three breaths with a long exhale at the open window	Six rounds of long exhales in bed
Place your feet consciously on the floor and feel them	Place your hands on your heart and belly and notice how you feel
Put an intention for the day into one sentence	Write down three things that were good today
A few minutes of movement, such as Cat-Cow on all fours	A few minutes lying with your legs up the wall

Setting your anchors

10 minutes

With this exercise you turn good intentions into concrete if-then plans that are easy to follow through.

1. Think about which action you're sure to do every morning, for example making coffee, brushing your teeth or waking the children.
2. Choose a small morning anchor that takes no longer than five minutes.
3. Complete the sentence: After I … , I will … . Write it on the lines below.
4. Repeat the same for the evening.
5. Put your two sentences somewhere you'll see them every day, such as on the bathroom mirror.
6. Try out your anchors for a week and adjust them if they don't feel right.

My anchors

My tip for you

Start really small, smaller than you think. Three breaths are better than a twenty-minute meditation you never do. Once an anchor feels natural after a few weeks, you can let it grow a little all by itself. And if you forget one day, simply carry on the next day without blaming yourself.

GOOD TO KNOW

How long it takes for a habit to stick

You often read that a new habit is established after 21 days. However, a well-known study from London led by Phillippa Lally showed that, on average, it took considerably longer for a new behaviour to feel automatic, and the range between individuals was very wide. The study also showed that the occasional missed day hardly affected the formation of the habit. So patience and kindness towards yourself matter more than perfection.

I shape my everyday life so that it carries me. Simple is enough.

Journal questions for week 4

At which moments in my week do I feel most rushed? What could lighten things there?

Which of my existing routines are good for me, and which do I keep up only out of habit?

Where can I consciously settle for good enough in future?

How does my week feel when I've planned it consciously beforehand?

Which morning or evening anchor felt most right this week?

My tracker for week 4

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Video “Pelvis in motion”	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Video “Calming your nervous system”	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Live call or recording	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Weekly planning done	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Morning anchor	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Evening anchor	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Enjoyed a buffer	○	○	○	○	○	○	○

MONTH IN REVIEW

What has grown?

The first month is behind you. Take time to look back, to honour what you've achieved and to look forward to next month with anticipation.

Four weeks have passed since you first opened this workbook. Perhaps it feels as though hardly any time has gone by, or perhaps it feels like a small eternity. In these weeks you've looked honestly at your life, made your invisible work visible, got to know your nervous system and tried out your first routines that lighten your load. That's quite a lot, and it deserves to be honoured.

Roots grow out of sight. From the outside you can hardly tell how much is happening under the soil, and yet they're the foundation for everything that will blossom later. Perhaps it's similar for you, and the changes are still small and quiet. Perhaps you notice them on a calmer evening, in a conversation you finally had, or in the moment when, for the first time, you chose the Tired Day video without a guilty conscience. It's precisely these small moments that count.

For your review, here's the scale from the first week once more. Fill it in without looking at what you entered back then, and only compare afterwards. Please be gentle with yourself: some numbers will have gone up, others may have stayed the same or even dropped, because you're now looking more closely. That too is progress.

How satisfied am I today with ...

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
my body and my movement										
my sleep and my rest										
my energy in everyday life										
my relationship										
my family and my home										
my friendships										
my work or my career										
my finances										
my creativity and my ideas										
time just for me										
my inner calm										
my self-worth										
	not at all									very

Comparing before and after

15 minutes

Place the scale from week 1 next to today's scale and take a calm look at the differences.

1. Mark every area in which your number has changed, in whichever direction.
2. For each area that has gone up, think about what contributed to it and write it down.
3. For areas that stayed the same or dropped, ask yourself whether you're simply looking more closely now or whether this area needs more attention.
4. Look at your focus area from week 1. What has shifted there, even if only a little?
5. Read your letter from spring once more. Which sentences already feel a little truer than they did four weeks ago?

My month at a glance

What I tried	What was good for me	What I would like to keep

My rituals until Month 2 begins

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
A movement video of my choice	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Long exhale	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Morning anchor	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Evening anchor	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Evening brain dump	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
One sentence in my journal	○	○	○	○	○	○	○

Journal questions for your month in review

What am I proud of this month, even if it may seem small?

What have I learnt about myself that I didn't know before?

Which task did I hand over, and how does that feel today?

Which tool from this month do I definitely want to take with me?

How has my relationship with my body changed in these four weeks?

What do I need in the coming weeks to take good care of myself?

I celebrate that this month I ...

- [ ] took time for myself
- [ ] looked honestly at my life
- [ ] made my mental load visible
- [ ] handed over at least one task
- [ ] understand my nervous system better
- [ ] found a breathing practice that works for me
- [ ] planned my week consciously
- [ ] was kind to myself, even on difficult days

My tip for you

Celebrate this first month consciously, even if you didn't manage everything. Treat yourself to something that brings you joy: a bath with your favourite scent, a walk in your favourite place or an unhurried coffee in a lovely café. Tell a friend or the women in our circle what you've discovered for yourself this month. Shared joy grows.

Looking ahead to Month 2: Buds

In the second month of Unfold, something new grows from your roots. We turn to your self-worth and your ideas. You'll learn to set boundaries without guilt, to say no without explaining yourself, and to say yes to yourself. You'll discover your strengths and values and what truly makes you feel alive. Together we'll look at the voice of the inner critic that sometimes keeps you small, and learn to answer it kindly. And finally, your ideas will at last be allowed to flow.

Your body will go a step further next month too. The movement videos make your spine more supple, open your heart space and let your strength slowly grow along with you. Everything you've built as a foundation this month will carry you. I'm so looking forward to walking this next stretch with you.

A look ahead

What am I most looking forward to in the second month?

Which idea or heartfelt wish is already quietly knocking at my door?

My roots are strong. I'm ready to grow.



Thank you for giving yourself this month. You've put down roots, and I can't wait to see, together with you, what grows from them. See you very soon in the second month. With love, Vivien.

♡ Vivien